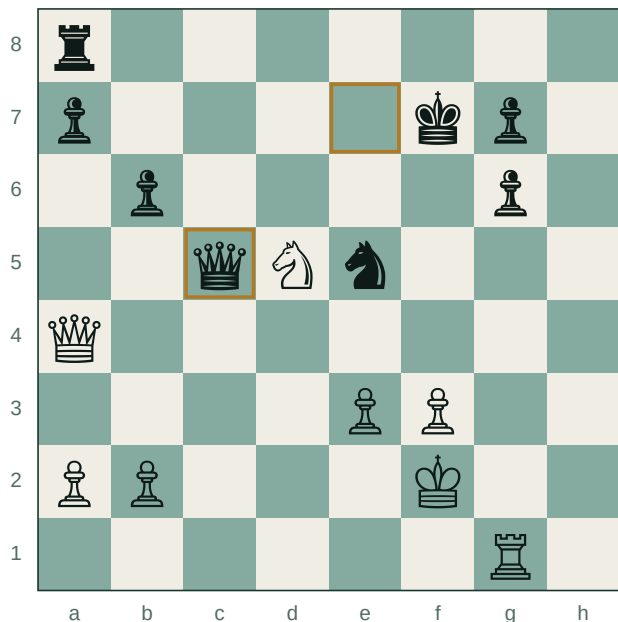


Forks and double attacks: White, move 26

Forks and double attacks

White to move



Previous move: 25...Qc5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26. Qf4+ Ke6 27. Qe4 Rf8 28. Rxc6+

26.Qf4+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From f4 it attacks king on f7 and knight on e5. Recorded reply: **26...Ke6**.

27.Qe4 The queen moves from f4 to e4. Recorded reply: **27...Rf8**.

28.Rxc6+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on g6.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Two attacked pieces do not guarantee a gain if the forking piece can be captured or one target moves with check.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A fork attacks multiple targets at once. The combination works when the defender cannot save everything or generate a stronger forcing reply.

HOW TO LOOK

Look for checking forks first, then double attacks on queens, rooks, and undefended pieces. Follow the line until the material is actually collected.

The defending king is on f7. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8 and knight on e5. Check for tactical protection.